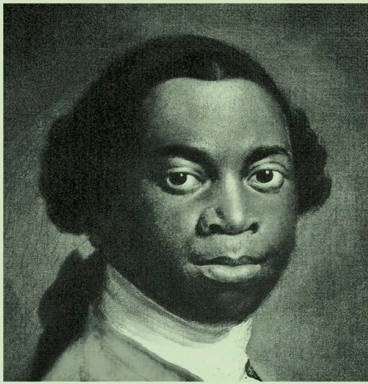




Olaudah Equiano

Kidnapped as a child of about 11 from his Nigerian home, Olaudah Equiano was shipped across the Atlantic, ending up in the plantations of Virginia. He was sold to a Royal Navy officer, Lieutenant Michael Henry Pascal, who renamed him Gustavus Vassa (after a 16th-century Swedish king).

Equiano spent 8 years at sea and, while with Pascal, learned to read and write and was baptized in 1759. He was later sold on to Philadelphia merchant Robert King, who allowed Equiano to trade a little for himself. Within 3 years, in 1766, he was able to buy his freedom. He worked on ships for the next 20 years, then settled in London in 1786, where he became involved in the abolitionist movement.

In 1789, Equiano published his autobiography, one of the first books by a black African writer. It was hugely popular, and Equiano toured around the country to tell his story. He died in London in 1797.

Key work

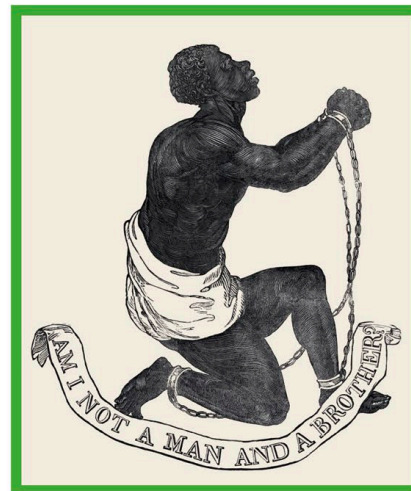
1789 *The Interesting Narrative of the Life of Olaudah Equiano, or Gustavus Vassa, the African*

of the slave trade because it seemed more achievable than the outright outlawing of slavery. The campaign quickly gained momentum. In 1788, in just 3 months, more than 100 anti-slavery petitions were delivered to Parliament.

One of the campaigners' key concerns was to give a voice to the Africans themselves by providing evidence and testimonies from escaped slaves and from sailors of slave ships, as well as accounts from freed slaves such as Olaudah Equiano (see left). He was literate, charming, and a Christian convert (which mattered in a fervently Christian society). Such stories helped rehumanize Africans in the eyes of the public and forced it to face the brutal reality of slavery.

The idea of human rights

Revolutions in the US (1775–1783) and France (1789–1799) made the late 18th century a period of political turmoil. Such popular movements highlighted the concept of human rights and inspired people to engage with activism. However, the threat of revolution made the British Parliament cautious. As the abolitionist movement grew in strength, it began to be portrayed



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Is one half of the human species, like the poor African slaves, to be subject to prejudices that brutalize them ...?

Mary Wollstonecraft
A Vindication of the Rights of Woman, 1792

”

as “radical.” This frustrated early efforts in Parliament to end slavery; anti-slavery bills were repeatedly blocked by the vested interests of those who profited from slavery and feared a collapse of the old order.

Unable to vote, let alone stand for election, women were largely barred from taking an active role in politics at this time, but activists such as Hannah More and Mary Wollstonecraft used their influence and writings to effect change. The burgeoning women's rights movement saw the oppression of women reflected in the plight of African slaves and often equated the two issues in their campaigns.

Slave revolts

While abolitionists were lobbying the British Parliament, slaves in the Caribbean were taking matters into their own hands. In Jamaica, the Maroons—escaped slaves and their descendants—had fought British colonialists for years and, in 1739,

Emotive designs, such as this by British potter Josiah Wedgwood in 1787, were used on medallions and other items to support the abolitionist cause.